A GENTLE, HONEST GUIDE
FOR YOUR JOINTS

The Joint Reset

Natural arthritis remedies, and what the evidence says

UNDERSTAND · SOOTHE · BUILD · KEEP GOING

YOUR PATH THROUGH THIS BOOK

What's inside

WELCOME

Before you begin 4

How this book works 7

PART ONE · UNDERSTAND

What's happening inside your joints 12

Know your arthritis 15

Where these remedies come from 18

Her nine laws of health, checked 21

The remedies at a glance 26

PART TWO · SOOTHE

Food and drink 37

Poultices, packs and warmth 45

Herbs, spices and supplements 53

Movement, your strongest medicine 58

A lighter load, deeper sleep, a calmer mind 62

Being kind to your joints all day 67

PART THREE · BUILD

A safe daily routine 71

Your first four weeks 73

A gentle movement guide 76

Your joint-friendly kitchen 78

When to see a doctor 81

PART FOUR · KEEP GOING

Your flare-day plan 85

Questions to bring to your doctor 86
Your weekly tracker 88
Questions people often ask 89
You made it 92

REFERENCE

Sources 95

WELCOME

Before you begin

If you're reading this, your joints have probably been deciding too much of your day. Which stairs you take. Whether you open the jar yourself. How long you can stand at the stove, sit in the car, or hold someone's hand.

You've likely been told a hundred different things about it. Cut this food. Drink that juice. Try this miracle. It's exhausting to hurt, and even more exhausting to not know who to believe.

This book was written for you, and it will be honest with you from the first page, because you deserve that. It will not cure your arthritis. Nothing can promise that. What it can do is real, though, and it matters.

Right now you may feel stiff in the morning, unsure what's safe to try, and a little afraid that things only go one direction from here. That

fear is understandable. It is also not the whole story, and the pages ahead will show you why.

By the last page, you'll know which natural remedies are worth your time and which are simply yours to choose. You'll have a simple daily routine you can start tomorrow. You'll understand your own condition well enough to ask your doctor better questions. With a few weeks of steady practice, many people find the mornings get easier, the pain gets quieter, and the things they'd stopped doing start to feel possible again.

That's the change on offer here: from confused to clear, from bracing against your body to working with it, from feeling like arthritis is running your life to feeling like you are.

PICTURE THIS

Before you turn the page, choose one thing you'd love to do with more ease three months from now. Kneeling in the garden. Walking to the corner shop. Getting down on the floor with a grandchild, and getting back up. Hold that picture. You'll come back to it in every part of this book, and each chapter is a step toward it.

YOUR QUICK WIN

Before you read another page, do this: stand up, or sit tall, and slowly circle each ankle ten times. Then drink a glass of water. That's it. You have already begun.

- [ ] I did my quick win today

Go gently. Take what helps. You're not doing this alone.

WELCOME

How this book works

This book is built so you feel a first win today, not in a month. It moves in four parts, and each one ends with a small milestone for you to tick off, so you can see your own progress as you go.

1. **Understand.** What is happening inside your joints, which kind of arthritis you have, and where every remedy stands.
2. **Soothe.** Food, warmth, herbs, movement, sleep and the small daily kindnesses that ease pain.
3. **Build.** Your daily routine, your first four weeks, a movement guide and a joint-friendly kitchen.
4. **Keep going.** Your plan for hard days, questions for your doctor, a tracker, and answers for the moments you doubt yourself.

THE FIVE VERDICTS

Every remedy in this book carries one of five tags, so you never have to guess where it stands.

- **Helps.** Tested in people and recommended in medical guidelines. Put your energy here first.
- **May help.** Early or modest evidence, and safe for most people. Worth a fair try.
- **Yours to try.** Not proven, but gentle and comforting. Enjoy it if you like it.
- **Free to use.** Research hasn't shown that it helps, so nothing is lost if you go without it. The choice is yours, and the note beside it tells you what to know.
- **Only with your doctor.** Worth doing only after you've spoken with your doctor, who can make it safe for you.

CHOOSE YOUR PACE

5 minutes

GO TO

Your quick win in "Before you begin"

WHAT YOU'LL WALK AWAY WITH

One thing done for your joints today

20 minutes

GO TO

The remedies at a glance, then A safe daily routine

WHAT YOU'LL WALK AWAY WITH

A clear picture and a plan for tomorrow

A quiet hour or two

GO TO

Read straight through

WHAT YOU'LL WALK AWAY WITH

The full understanding, at your own pace

The next month

GO TO

Your first four weeks

WHAT YOU'LL WALK AWAY WITH

A routine that has become yours

A NOTE ON SAFETY

This book is here to inform and encourage you. It sits alongside your medical care and never replaces it. If you take prescription medication, change it only after speaking with your doctor, and tell your doctor or pharmacist about anything new you'd like to try.

COMING NEXT

You're about to see inside your own joints. Once you understand what is really going on in there, the remedies that work will make perfect sense, and so will the ones that don't.

PART ONE

Understand

The fog is about to lift. In the next few chapters you'll learn what is happening inside your joints, which kind of arthritis is yours, and exactly which remedies deserve your energy.

PART ONE · UNDERSTAND

What's happening inside your joints

You don't need a medical degree to understand your joints. You only need a clear picture, and once you have it, you'll feel more in charge of your body than you have in a long time.

A joint is where two bones meet. The ends of those bones are capped with cartilage, a smooth, springy tissue that lets them glide. The whole joint is wrapped in a thin lining that makes a slippery fluid, a little like oil in a hinge. Muscles and tendons around the joint hold it steady and take up much of the load.

WHY MOVEMENT IS MEDICINE

Here is the fact that changes everything: cartilage has no blood supply of its own. It is fed by the joint fluid, and that fluid only moves in and out of the cartilage when the joint itself moves. Every gentle bend and stretch is a meal for your cartilage. Rest starves it. As she puts it in her talks, movement brings blood, and blood

brings what a joint needs. This is why the joints you move kindly and often are the ones that serve you longest.

WHAT GOES WRONG

In arthritis, something disturbs that system. The cartilage may thin and roughen. The lining may become inflamed and swollen. Crystals may form inside the joint. The result is the same family of symptoms you know well: pain, stiffness, swelling, and a joint that tires quickly.

WHY PAIN IS NOT THE SAME AS DAMAGE

This may be the most freeing idea in the book. Pain is a signal made by your nervous system, and it is turned up or down by many things: poor sleep, stress, fear, cold, low mood, and sitting still for too long. It is very common for joints that look worn on an X-ray to feel fine, and for joints that look healthy to hurt. So a painful day does not mean your joints are crumbling. It means your system is sensitive today, and you have more ways to calm it than you may think.

THE THREE LEVERS YOU HOLD

Everything that works in this book pulls one of three levers. It lightens the load on the joint, it calms inflammation, or it settles a sensitive nervous system. Movement, sleep and food pull all three at once, which is why you'll meet them again and again.

PICTURE THIS

Think of the joint that bothers you most. Now picture it warm, well fed and moving a little more freely each week. That is what the next chapters are for.

COMING NEXT

Not all arthritis is the same, and knowing which kind is yours is the single most useful thing you'll learn. It's on the very next page.

PART ONE · UNDERSTAND

Know your arthritis

Knowing which kind of arthritis you have is the most caring thing you can do for your joints, because each kind needs something different. Popular talks often gather them under one cause, such as "acidity" or "toxins". They are really different conditions, and understanding yours puts you back in charge.

Osteoarthritis

WHAT IS HAPPENING

Gradual wear and repair of cartilage and joint tissue, most often in knees, hips, hands and spine

WHAT CONTROLS IT

Exercise, weight loss, pain relief, sometimes joint replacement

Rheumatoid arthritis

WHAT IS HAPPENING

The immune system attacks the joint lining, often in both hands or both feet at once

WHAT CONTROLS IT

Prescription disease-modifying drugs, started early

Gout

WHAT IS HAPPENING

Uric acid crystals form in a joint, often the big toe, causing sudden severe attacks

WHAT CONTROLS IT

Urate-lowering medication, plus diet and alcohol changes

HOW EACH ONE TENDS TO FEEL

- **Osteoarthritis:** stiffness that eases within about half an hour of getting up, pain that builds with use, and joints that may creak or look knobbly.
- **Rheumatoid arthritis:** morning stiffness lasting more than an hour, warm and swollen joints on both sides of the body, and often deep tiredness.

- **Gout:** a single joint that becomes hot, red and exquisitely tender, often overnight, then settles over days.

Other kinds exist too, such as psoriatic arthritis and ankylosing spondylitis. Like rheumatoid arthritis, they are driven by the immune system and are looked after by a rheumatologist.

If yours is rheumatoid arthritis, please hold on to this: the medication is what protects your joints from lasting damage, and the early months matter most. Let the remedies in this book comfort you alongside it.

If you don't have a diagnosis yet, that isn't a failing. It's simply the first step, and taking it is an act of care for yourself.

COMING NEXT

Next, a short and honest word about where the remedies in this book come from, and why you can trust what you're about to read.

Where these remedies come from

Many of the remedies in this book, such as ginger poultices, castor oil compresses, alternating hot and cold water and "alkaline" eating, were made popular by the natural health speaker Barbara O'Neill. This edition draws directly on two of her talks on arthritis and gout, so you can see what she actually teaches, with every idea checked.

WHY HER STORY STAYS WITH ME

I want to tell you why I couldn't put her story down. She was in her early twenties when she watched her mother, still in her forties, lose the use of her hands and then her legs to rheumatoid arthritis. It began soon after a stressful house move. She was treated with long-term steroids, anti-inflammatories and gold injections, grew steadily worse, and died at 51, by then in a wheelchair. Her father came to believe that the anger her mother carried about the move had played a part. Near the end, a

family friend who used natural remedies cared for her with juices, a plant-based diet, water, sunshine and gentle massage, and for about six weeks her pain eased.

What moves me is the daughter in that story. Anyone who has watched someone they love hurt, and felt there was nothing they could do, will recognise her. She took that helplessness and turned it into a lifetime of handing people something to do with their own two hands. That is the reason I wrote this book: so that you are never left with nothing to do.

I also wanted to be fair to you, so I looked into the story's background. Her mother was treated half a century ago, before the medicines used for rheumatoid arthritis today existed. Modern disease-modifying drugs do far more than dull pain. They slow or stop the joint damage itself, which is why far fewer people with rheumatoid arthritis lose the use of their hands and legs now. And while stress can certainly stir up pain, rheumatoid arthritis is not caused by a person's feelings. No one brings it on themselves.

WHAT SHE GETS RIGHT

Listen closely and much of her talk is simply good sense. Drink water. Sleep well. Eat mostly plants. Ease off sugar. Keep a healthy weight. Move every day. Notice how your body responds. She is right, too, that arthritis often settles in a joint that was injured years before. You will find all of that in this book, because research supports it.

THE FULL PICTURE

You deserve the whole truth as well. She has no recognised medical qualifications, and in 2019 the health regulator in New South Wales, Australia, permanently prohibited her from providing health services after finding that some of her advice put people at risk. A few claims in these very talks fall into that category, and the next chapter names them plainly so you can use her teaching safely.

You are not being asked to choose between natural care and medical care. The best results come from both.

COMING NEXT

Her whole approach rests on nine simple habits. Turn the page to see each one, and where it truly stands.

PART ONE · UNDERSTAND

Her nine laws of health, checked

At the heart of her teaching are the habits she calls the laws of health. She counts eight in some talks and nine in others; these are the nine from her arthritis seminar. She believes that when these are in place the body heals itself, and that poultices and herbs only assist. Here is each one, in her order, with an honest verdict.

Sunshine

Yours to try

WHAT SHE TEACHES

A little sun every day for vitamin D

WHAT TO KNOW

Daylight lifts mood and tops up vitamin D. It has not been shown to ease arthritis, so enjoy it and protect fair skin.

Water

May help

WHAT SHE TEACHES

At least eight glasses a day to keep joints lubricated

WHAT TO KNOW

A good habit, and truly useful in gout. Joint fluid is made by the joint lining, so extra glasses don't oil a joint directly.

Sleep

May help

WHAT SHE TEACHES

Early nights, with at least two hours before midnight

WHAT TO KNOW

Enough regular sleep turns pain down. The routine matters more than the hour on the clock.

Trust

May help

WHAT SHE TEACHES

Faith, gratitude and hope

WHAT TO KNOW

A calm, hopeful mind eases pain. If faith is part of your life, lean on it.

Abstain

May help

WHAT SHE TEACHES

Stop sugar, caffeine, alcohol and tobacco

WHAT TO KNOW

Stopping smoking and limiting alcohol are real wins: smoking worsens rheumatoid arthritis and alcohol triggers gout. Less sugar helps your weight. Tea and coffee are fine for most people.

Inhale

Yours to try

WHAT SHE TEACHES

Breathe through the nose, and sleep with fresh air in the room

WHAT TO KNOW

Slow nose breathing is calming and fresh air is pleasant. Neither sends extra oxygen to your joints.

Nutrition May help

WHAT SHE TEACHES

A plant-based diet, about 80% "alkaline" foods

WHAT TO KNOW

The plants do the good. The acid theory behind it isn't needed.

Moderation May help

WHAT SHE TEACHES

Good things in sensible amounts

WHAT TO KNOW

Sensible portions support a healthy weight, and your knees feel the difference.

Exercise Helps

WHAT SHE TEACHES

Move every day

WHAT TO KNOW

The strongest remedy in this book, and the one she and the guidelines agree on completely.

HER METHOD FOR FINDING WHAT WORKS

She teaches a simple routine: look back over your history, notice what your symptoms are telling you, change one habit, then watch how

your body responds. "Does it bring relief?" is her test. That is a sound way to try any gentle remedy, and it is exactly what your tracker in Part four is for. Just keep your doctor in the loop, because some causes can't be found by feel.

THREE IDEAS FROM THE TALKS TO TAKE TO YOUR DOCTOR FIRST

- **"Drugs never cure, they only mask symptoms."** For rheumatoid arthritis, modern medicines do more than that: they protect joints from permanent damage. She suggests easing off medication as lifestyle changes take hold. Only do that after speaking with your doctor, who can lower a dose safely as you improve.
- **"Autoimmune disease isn't real."** It is. Rheumatoid arthritis shows up in blood tests and scans. It can go quiet for long stretches, which is called remission and is most often reached with treatment.
- **"Castor oil breaks up tumours, bone spurs, scar tissue and calcified joints."** There is no evidence for this. Any new lump deserves a doctor, not a compress.

Keep the nine habits, and take those three ideas to your doctor. You now see her teaching more clearly than most people who have watched it.

COMING NEXT

Now for the whole picture in one place: every remedy from her talks and beyond, sorted, so you know exactly where to begin.

PART ONE · UNDERSTAND

The remedies at a glance

Here is the whole picture in one place, so you can see where to put your energy first. Four of these are proven helpers, seven may help, six are gentle comforts, five are free to use, and two are for after a talk with your doctor.

Regular movement Helps

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Keeps joints nourished

WHAT TO KNOW

Strongly recommended in osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis guidelines

Losing excess weight Helps

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Takes load off joints

WHAT TO KNOW

Strongly recommended for knee and hip osteoarthritis

Cayenne on the skin Helps

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Eases pain

WHAT TO KNOW

Capsaicin cream is conditionally recommended for knee osteoarthritis

Tai chi

Helps

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Gentle strength and balance

WHAT TO KNOW

Strongly recommended for knee and hip osteoarthritis

Whole-food, plant-rich eating

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Calms inflammation

WHAT TO KNOW

Good for weight and overall health; a Mediterranean-style pattern is suggested in rheumatoid arthritis

Turmeric

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

A natural anti-inflammatory

WHAT TO KNOW

Early trials are encouraging for knee osteoarthritis

Ginger, eaten or as a poultice

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Eases joint pain

WHAT TO KNOW

A small benefit when eaten; the poultice soothes through warmth

Hot and cold packs

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Relieves stiffness and swelling

WHAT TO KNOW

Conditionally recommended for short-term relief

Alternating hot and cold water

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Floods the joint with fresh blood

WHAT TO KNOW

Warmth and cold each ease pain for a while; the alternating routine is less studied but safe with comfortably warm water

Oily fish and fish oil

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Calms inflamed joints

WHAT TO KNOW

Modest relief of pain and morning stiffness in rheumatoid arthritis; not shown to help osteoarthritis

Comfrey cream

May help

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Speeds healing of sore joints

WHAT TO KNOW

A three-week trial found it eased knee osteoarthritis pain; for unbroken skin only, never swallowed

Castor oil packs

Yours to try

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Reduces inflammation

WHAT TO KNOW

Not proven, but the warmth and rest can feel lovely

Carrot, celery and apple juice

Yours to try

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Alkalises the tissues

WHAT TO KNOW

A pleasant drink with no proven effect on joints; whole vegetables do more

Epsom salt baths

Yours to try

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Draws out soreness

WHAT TO KNOW

The warm water is what soothes; the salt is optional

Lemon water in the morning

Yours to try

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Alkalises the body

WHAT TO KNOW

Refreshing and harmless; rinse with plain water to protect your teeth

A big breakfast and a light supper

Yours to try

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Easier weight loss

WHAT TO KNOW

Some small studies support eating more earlier in the day

Breathing through the nose

Yours to try

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

More oxygen for healing

WHAT TO KNOW

Calming, though it doesn't change the oxygen in your joints

Cutting nightshades

Free to use

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Removes a joint irritant

WHAT TO KNOW

Research has not found a link, so you're just as free to keep the foods you love; the two-week test will tell you

"Alkalising" the body

Free to use

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Balances acidity

WHAT TO KNOW

Food doesn't change blood pH; the vegetables are what help

Extra salt in water

Free to use

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Better hydration

WHAT TO KNOW

Water alone does the job; go without the salt if you have high blood pressure

Glucosamine

Free to use

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Rebuilds cartilage

WHAT TO KNOW

Safe for most people, though the largest trials found little or no benefit

Cutting wheat, dairy or cooked greens

Free to use

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Removes acid-forming foods

WHAT TO KNOW

No evidence these worsen arthritis, so you're just as free to keep them; low-fat dairy is linked with fewer gout flares

Turmeric at 8,000 mg a day

Only with your doctor

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

A stronger anti-inflammatory

WHAT TO KNOW

Many times the amount used in trials; the dose on the label is the tested one

Reducing your medication

Only with your doctor

THE HOPE BEHIND IT

Natural care alone

WHAT TO KNOW

Your doctor can lower a dose safely as you improve, which matters most in inflammatory arthritis

MILESTONE 1

You understand

You now know more about arthritis remedies than most people ever learn. Take a breath and tick these off.

- [ ] I know, or have a plan to find out, which type of arthritis I have
- [ ] I understand that movement feeds my joints
- [ ] I know which three ideas to talk through with my doctor first
- [ ] I've picked one "Helps" idea to try first

COMING NEXT

Understanding was the first step. Now comes the part you've been waiting for: relief you can feel, starting in your own kitchen.

PART TWO

Soothe

This is where relief begins. Six gentle chapters, each one giving you something real to do for your joints today.

Food and drink

Food is one of the kindest tools you have, and it works in a simple way: by easing the load on your joints, calming inflammation and looking after your whole body. You don't need to chase acid or toxins to feel the benefit.

Anti-inflammatory eating May help

Here the popular advice is on solid ground. Filling your plate with vegetables, fruit, beans, nuts and whole grains, and easing off sugar and processed food, is exactly what mainstream guidance suggests too. A Mediterranean-style pattern with olive oil and oily fish has the best support, and the American College of Rheumatology suggests it for people with rheumatoid arthritis. The change is gradual and gentle, and it is real.

Oily fish May help

Salmon, sardines, mackerel and herring are rich in omega-3 fats. In rheumatoid arthritis, studies of fish oil show a modest easing of joint pain

and morning stiffness. Two portions a week is a lovely habit for your joints and your heart alike.

Nightshades

You can keep them

In her talk she advises people with arthritis to stop potatoes, tomatoes, peppers and eggplant until the arthritis is conquered, blaming plant chemicals called lectins. Research hasn't found that link, the Arthritis Foundation calls it a myth, and these foods nourish you. She also says something wise here: people differ, and your own body's response is the real test. So if you suspect a food, leave it out for two weeks, bring it back, and let your body answer. Peeling and deseeding tomatoes and peppers, as she suggests, is harmless if you'd like to try it. One exception is worth knowing: in gout, some people do find that tomatoes set off a flare, and one study linked them with higher uric acid, so the two-week test is especially worthwhile for you. Sweet potatoes, as she says, are not nightshades at all.

Alkaline eating

Keep the food, let go of the worry

If you've felt better eating this way, that feeling is genuine. The credit belongs to all those

vegetables rather than to pH. She accepts that your blood stays steady whatever you eat, and argues that the fluid around your cells and joints turns acid instead. Your body guards that just as carefully, and no study has shown that food changes the acidity of a joint. So enjoy the meals, and set down any fear of "acidic" foods.

HER 80/20 PLATE

She suggests filling about 70 to 80% of your plate with what she calls alkaline foods and keeping everything else to 20 or 30%. Set the chemistry aside and this is simply a plant-rich plate, which is good advice.

- **Her 80%:** leafy greens and other vegetables, fruit, lemon, millet, quinoa, buckwheat, spelt, kamut, einkorn, almonds, Brazil nuts, lima beans, lentils, soy and seeds.
- **Her 20%:** meat, aged cheese, modern wheat, other grains, other beans and other nuts, with sugar, caffeine and alcohol kept lowest of all.

- **One kind correction:** walnuts, oats and chickpeas sit on her "acid" side, and oily fish isn't on her plate at all. These are some of the best foods there are for your joints and heart. Enjoy them freely.
- **Cooked greens are welcome too.** She advises eating spinach and chard raw only, saying that cooking turns them acid. It doesn't. Cooked greens are just as good for you, and often easier to eat in generous amounts.

Carrot, celery and apple juice

Yours to try

Her signature juice is about 80% carrot, 10% celery and 10% apple, once or twice a day. It's a pleasant drink and a gentle way to take in vegetables. It hasn't been shown to ease joints, clear uric acid or change your body's acidity, and juice carries more sugar and less fibre than whole vegetables, so one small glass is plenty. If you have diabetes, count it as you would any juice.

Lemon water

Yours to try

She suggests the juice of a lemon in water each morning. It's refreshing and harmless, though it won't alkalise you. Rinse with plain water afterwards to be kind to your teeth.

Water and salt

The water is the gift

Drinking enough through the day, around the eight glasses she suggests, is a lovely, simple habit, and it helps keep gout flares away. You can leave out the Celtic or sea salt. It adds nothing for your joints, and your heart and blood pressure will thank you for skipping it.

HER SIPPING TRICK

If you avoid water because you worry about rushing to the bathroom, she suggests adding one glass a day and taking it a few mouthfuls at a time. It's a gentle, sensible way to drink more. If your doctor has set a fluid limit for your heart or kidneys, keep to that.

Sugar and processed food

Less is kinder

She speaks strongly against refined sugar, and on the practical point she is right. Sweet drinks,

pastries and heavily processed meals make weight harder to manage and tend to leave people feeling more inflamed and tired. You don't have to give them up forever. Swapping one a day is enough to start feeling lighter.

Tea and coffee

You can keep them

She links her mother's tea drinking to her arthritis. There is no good evidence that moderate tea or coffee causes or worsens arthritis, and both count toward your fluids. If caffeine disturbs your sleep, stop after lunch.

Wheat and bread

You can keep them

She blames modern wheat for inflammation and suggests ancient grains such as spelt, kamut and einkorn. Those are lovely grains, and the wholegrain form of any wheat is good for you. There is no good evidence that wheat worsens arthritis unless you have coeliac disease or a diagnosed sensitivity. If you suspect it, ask your doctor for a coeliac test before you cut wheat out, because the test only works while you're still eating it.

Milk, yoghurt and cheese

You can keep them

She places aged cheese on her "acid" list. For gout, the evidence points the other way: low-fat milk and yoghurt are linked with fewer flares. Keep rich cheese to modest portions for the sake of your weight and heart.

Red and processed meat

Less is kinder

Here she and the evidence lean the same way, for different reasons. It isn't about acid. Red meat is rich in purines, which matter in gout, and a plate with more fish, beans and vegetables is the pattern with the best support.

A big breakfast and a light supper

Yours to try

Her rule is to eat breakfast like a king, lunch like a queen and supper like a pauper. Some small studies suggest that eating more of your food earlier in the day makes weight loss a little easier, and many people sleep better after a light evening meal. If you take medicines with food at night, keep doing so.

IF YOURS IS GOUT

Food matters more in gout than in any other arthritis, so here is what truly protects you. The American College of Rheumatology suggests limiting alcohol (beer and spirits most of all), limiting purine-rich foods such as organ meats, red meat and shellfish, and avoiding drinks sweetened with high-fructose corn syrup. Losing excess weight helps too. Cherries have been linked with fewer flares in some studies, so enjoy them, though they are not proven. Vitamin C tablets are not recommended. And if flares keep returning, medication that lowers uric acid is what stops them for good.

PICTURE THIS

Imagine opening your fridge a month from now and seeing food that is on your side. What is the first thing you'd like to find there?

You don't have to overhaul your kitchen overnight. One better meal a day is a real start, and your joints will not hold a tomato against you.

COMING NEXT

Next comes the most comforting chapter in the book: warmth, poultices, and the one remedy from the spice rack that truly quiets pain.

PART TWO · SOOTHE

Poultices, packs and warmth

Poultices are the best known of all the natural remedies, and there is something deeply comforting about tending a sore joint with your own hands. One of them, cayenne, has real evidence behind it.

Cayenne Helps

This one truly works. Capsaicin, the compound that gives chilli its heat, quiets pain signals when used regularly. A pharmacy capsaicin cream is the gentlest way to use it, because the strength is measured for you. It is recommended for knee osteoarthritis in particular.

1. Apply a thin layer to the sore joint three or four times a day.
2. Expect warmth or stinging for the first one to two weeks. It fades as the nerves settle.
3. Wash your hands afterwards and keep it away from eyes and broken skin.
4. Give it two to four weeks before judging it. Relief builds quietly.

Heat and cold

May help

These are simple and they work for many people. Warmth loosens stiffness; give it 15 to 20 minutes with a heat pack, a warm shower or a wheat bag. A cold pack wrapped in a cloth calms a hot, swollen joint. A good rule: warm what is stiff, cool what is swollen. Skip both on skin that feels numb.

Alternating hot and cold water

May help

This is the first thing she reaches for when a joint hurts, and it suits hands, wrists, feet and ankles beautifully.

1. Fill one bowl with comfortably warm water and one with cold. Warm means bath temperature, about 40°C (104°F), never hot enough to redden your skin.
2. Soak the joint in the warm bowl for three minutes, then in the cold bowl for 30 seconds.
3. Repeat three times, about ten to twelve minutes in all.
4. Dry off and move the joint gently while it is warm and loose.

She reports pain dropping by half in those twelve minutes. Research on alternating baths is limited, so take that as her experience and not a promise. Warmth and cold each ease pain for a while, and this is a pleasant way to use both. If you have numbness, poor circulation or diabetes affecting your feet, check with your doctor first.

FOR HIPS, KNEES AND SHOULDERS

A bowl won't reach these, so she offers two ways. The easy one is the shower: with a handheld shower head, run comfortably warm water over the joint for three minutes, then cool

water for 30 seconds, three times. The other is a warm, wrung-out towel laid over a dry towel on the joint, swapped for a cold cloth. She wrings her towels from boiling water. Please use hot tap water and test it on your inner wrist first, because boiling water scalds.

Ginger poultice May help

She calls this the best poultice for a sore joint, and uses it straight after the hot and cold water.

1. Grate a heaped teaspoon of fresh ginger onto the centre of a thin cotton cloth about 20 cm (8 inches) square. A piece of old sheet is ideal.
2. Fold the sides in to make a flat parcel, and place the single-layer side against your skin.
3. Cover it with a piece of plastic and bandage it on, snug but not tight.
4. Start with one joint, for up to an hour in the early evening and never straight before bed. Then remove it and rinse the skin.

She uses it for one to three hours and has left it on overnight. The shorter time is kinder to your skin. The warmth you feel is the ginger

stimulating your skin. She describes burning as inflammation being drawn out, but burning is simply irritated skin, so take the poultice off as soon as it stings. She tells of a woman who wore one three times in a day and woke with blisters, and her advice then is the right one: don't overdo it, and rest the skin for a week. Eating ginger has the better evidence, and you'll meet it in the next chapter.

Castor oil compress Yours to try

This is her overnight remedy. She wore one on a sore thumb joint every night for six months and says the tenderness went.

1. Fold soft cotton cloth into about six layers, or use three layers of towelling, large enough to wrap the joint.
2. Pour a small pool of castor oil into the centre and leave it for 15 minutes to soak through. Too much and it will leak onto your bedding.
3. Wrap it round the joint, cover with plastic and bandage it on overnight.
4. Fold it away in the morning and reuse it for a month or more, adding half a teaspoon of oil about once a week.

It hasn't been tested in trials for arthritis, and one person's experience can't tell us whether the oil, the warmth or simply time did the healing. It is gentle on unbroken skin, though, and many people find the warmth and stillness a comfort. She also says it breaks up scar tissue, bone spurs and calcified joints. Nothing supports that, so use it for comfort and expect no more. Keep it on the outside only; swallowed, castor oil is a strong laxative.

Epsom salt bath Yours to try

A warm bath is one of life's reliable comforts, and it eases stiff joints and tired muscles beautifully. There is no good evidence that magnesium passes through the skin, so the relief comes from the warm water itself. Add the salts if you enjoy them.

Warm wax for hands May help

A paraffin wax bath, found at pharmacies and used by hand therapists, wraps stiff fingers in gentle, even heat. It is suggested in guidelines for hand osteoarthritis and can make the first movements of the day much easier.

Comfrey cream May help

When an old elbow injury starts to ache, she adds comfrey cream to her hot and cold water and ginger. This one has some real support: in a three-week trial of 220 people, comfrey root ointment eased knee osteoarthritis pain far more than a dummy cream, though the study was run by the maker. Buy a ready-made cream, use it on unbroken skin for a few weeks at a time, and never swallow comfrey or use it in pregnancy, because the plant contains compounds that can harm the liver.

SKIN SAFETY

Test any poultice on a small patch first. Do not leave a ginger or cayenne poultice on overnight, and do not use heat over a cream that already warms the skin.

- Never apply heat or cold for more than 20 minutes at a time.
- Keep a cloth between a cold pack and your skin.
- If you have diabetes or poor circulation, check with your doctor before using heat or cold on your feet.

There is comfort in the ritual too. Ten quiet minutes with something warm on a sore joint is time spent looking after yourself, and that counts.

COMING NEXT

Two spices already in your kitchen have been tested in real trials. The next chapter tells you what they can do, and which popular supplements you can stop paying for.

PART TWO · SOOTHE

Herbs, spices and supplements

The supplement aisle makes a great many promises. This chapter will save you money and worry by telling you plainly which ones have earned their place.

Turmeric May help

There is honest reason for hope here. The US National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health describes the early evidence for knee osteoarthritis as positive, though higher-quality studies are still needed. Cooking with turmeric, or stirring it into warm milk, is a

pleasant habit; just know it gives far less curcumin than the extracts used in trials.

HER TURMERIC ADVICE, CHECKED

She suggests taking up to 8,000 mg a day. Osteoarthritis trials have mostly used around 500 to 1,500 mg of curcumin extract a day, so that is many times the tested amount, and higher doses bring more stomach upset and more risk. Go above the dose on the label only after speaking with your doctor. She also swaps black pepper for cayenne, saying it holds the same absorption booster. It doesn't. That compound, piperine, comes from black pepper, while cayenne's is capsaicin. Cayenne in your cooking is fine. It just won't boost turmeric.

CAUTIONS FOR TURMERIC SUPPLEMENTS

- Standard products are considered likely safe for up to two to three months.
- "High-absorption" formulations have been linked to liver injury. Stop and see a doctor if you notice dark urine, yellowing skin, nausea, poor appetite or unusual tiredness.

- Supplements may be unsafe in pregnancy. Turmeric in food is fine.
- Check with a pharmacist if you take blood thinners or diabetes medication.

Ginger

May help

In food, tea or a supplement, ginger has eased osteoarthritis pain a little. A review of five trials in nearly 600 people found a small but real reduction in pain and disability. Go gently if it gives you heartburn, and mention it to your pharmacist if you take blood thinners.

Fish oil

May help in rheumatoid arthritis

A review of 22 trials found that fish oil modestly reduces pain in rheumatoid arthritis, and it may ease morning stiffness. It has not been shown to help osteoarthritis. Eating oily fish twice a week is the simplest way to get it. If you'd prefer capsules, ask your doctor first, especially if you take blood thinners.

Glucosamine and chondroitin

Free to use

These are the best-selling joint supplements in the world, which is why this may surprise you.

The largest and best studies found little or no benefit, and osteoarthritis guidelines don't recommend glucosamine. They are safe for most people, so if you feel they help, you're free to carry on. If you've been buying them for years without feeling a difference, you're just as free to stop.

Vitamin D

Only if you're low

Vitamin D matters for bones, and it's worth correcting if a blood test shows you're short. Taking extra has not been shown to ease arthritis pain.

Thunder god vine

Please avoid

This herb appears in some arthritis blends. It can cause serious side effects, and health authorities warn that its risks may outweigh its benefits.

BEFORE YOU BUY ANYTHING

Supplements are not checked the way medicines are, so quality varies. Choose one product at a time, give it eight to twelve weeks, and keep it only if you can feel a difference. Always tell your doctor and pharmacist what you take.

One thing to hold on to if you have rheumatoid arthritis: herbs can comfort you, but they haven't been shown to protect joints from damage. Your medication does that part.

COMING NEXT

You've reached the chapter that matters most. If you only ever act on one part of this book, the next few pages are the ones that will change how your body feels.

Movement, your strongest medicine

If you take only one thing from this book, let it be this chapter. Movement is the most powerful natural remedy there is, and here the popular advice and the medical guidelines agree completely.

Movement Helps

The American College of Rheumatology and the Arthritis Foundation strongly recommend exercise for osteoarthritis, and consistent exercise is the single strongest recommendation in the guideline for rheumatoid arthritis too. It feeds cartilage, strengthens the muscles that protect your joints, lifts your mood and deepens your sleep.

You may be worried that exercise will wear your joints out faster. It's a very common fear, and the research is reassuring: sensible movement does not speed up arthritis. Stillness is what makes joints stiffer, weaker and more painful.

FOUR KINDS OF MOVEMENT, AND WHAT EACH GIVES YOU

- **Walking, cycling or swimming.** Builds stamina and eases stiffness. Work toward 30 minutes on most days, in pieces as short as five or ten minutes.
- **Strength work.** Strong thighs take load off knees; strong hips steady your walk. Twice a week is enough to feel a difference.
- **Tai chi or yoga.** Slow, flowing movement that builds balance and calm. Tai chi is strongly recommended for knee and hip osteoarthritis, and yoga is suggested for knees.
- **Water exercise.** Warm water carries your weight, so sore joints can move freely. Many people who dread exercise on land love it in a pool.

HER JOINT-FRIENDLY THREE

In her talk she recommends a mini trampoline, an exercise bike and swimming, because none of them jar the joints. The bike and the pool are excellent choices with good research behind them. Swimming is her first choice when joints are very sore, because the water carries your weight, and a kickboard or the pool edge is all you need if you can't swim. The bike suits anyone unsteady on their feet. A mini trampoline is gentle too if you keep your feet on the mat and simply lift your heels, which she calls the health bounce. Choose one with a support bar, because balance comes first. She says bouncing clears waste through the lymph system. Any movement helps blood and lymph to flow, so you don't need a trampoline for that.

HOW TO KNOW YOU'RE DOING IT RIGHT

- Mild soreness that settles within a day is normal and safe. It means your body is adapting.

- If you hurt more than usual for over two hours afterwards, do a little less next time. Less, not nothing.
- Sharp, sudden or lasting pain means stop that movement and ask a physiotherapist.
- On good days, resist the urge to do everything. Steady beats heroic.

A physiotherapist can build a programme around the joints that hurt, which matters most if you have been inactive or have had a joint replaced.

PICTURE THIS

Think back to the picture you chose on the first page. Which muscles will carry you there? Every walk and every chair stand is a deposit toward that day.

If moving hurts today, start smaller than feels worthwhile. Five minutes is not nothing. It's how the easier mornings begin.

COMING NEXT

Movement has three quiet partners that make everything else work better. You'll meet them next, and one of them happens while you're asleep.

PART TWO · SOOTHE

A lighter load, deeper sleep, a calmer mind

These three are rarely talked about in remedy books, and yet each one turns the volume of pain down. Think of them as the soil the other remedies grow in.

Weight

Helps

Losing excess weight is strongly recommended for knee and hip osteoarthritis, and the reason is wonderfully encouraging. A study of 142 adults with knee osteoarthritis found that each pound lost took about four pounds of pressure off the knee with every step. Over a single mile, that adds up to thousands of pounds your knees

no longer have to carry. Weight loss also lowers the risk of gout flares.

You do not need to reach an "ideal" weight to feel this. Losing even a little brings relief, and the eating pattern from the food chapter is the gentlest way to get there. No crash diets. They don't last, and you deserve better.

A STORY FROM HER TALK

A couple in their late sixties, both overweight and sore, had moved into a care home. They changed how they ate, gave up their nightly wine, drank more water and exercised every morning, and over six months they lost around 20 kilos. Their knees and feet felt the difference, their blood tests improved, and their doctor took them off their anti-inflammatories. A year later they left the care home, bought a caravan and set off around Australia. It is one couple's story and not a promise. Notice what did the work, though: a lighter load, daily movement, and a doctor who adjusted their medicines as they improved. That is exactly the path this book lays out for you.

Sleep May help

Poor sleep lowers your pain threshold, so everything hurts more the next day, and pain then disturbs the following night. You can break that circle from the sleep side.

- Keep a regular bedtime and waking time, even at weekends.
- Take a warm shower or bath before bed to loosen stiff joints.
- Keep the room dark and cool, with a little fresh air if you like it, and ease off caffeine after lunch.
- Tuck a pillow between your knees if you sleep on your side, or under them if you sleep on your back.
- If pain wakes you most nights, tell your doctor. It is treatable.

A calmer mind May help

Stress and worry tighten muscles and sensitise nerves. Calming practices do the opposite. Studies in rheumatoid arthritis found that mindfulness and similar approaches eased pain and stiffness as a useful addition to standard care, and talking therapy for pain is suggested in osteoarthritis guidelines.

A TWO-MINUTE CALM

Sit comfortably and rest your hands in your lap. Breathe in through your nose for a count of four and out through your mouth for a count of six. Repeat ten times. A longer out-breath tells your nervous system it is safe to soften. Try it now, before the next chapter.

Setting down resentment

May help

She tells how her mother carried anger about a move she never wanted, and how the family came to believe it fed her illness. Feelings do not cause arthritis, and you did not bring yours on yourself. What is true is that long-held anger keeps the body tense and pain turned up. Talking it through, forgiving where you can, praying if you pray, or simply writing it down can lighten what you carry.

Rest is not laziness, and calm is not a luxury. They are part of your treatment.

COMING NEXT

One more chapter in this part, and it's full of small, clever changes that take strain off your joints from the moment you get up.

PART TWO · SOOTHE

Being kind to your joints all day

Relief isn't only found in remedies. It's also found in how you carry a bag, open a jar and plan your afternoon. Occupational therapists teach these habits, and they can spare your joints a great deal of strain.

SHARE THE LOAD

- Use your largest, strongest joints for the job. Push a door with your shoulder or forearm, and carry bags on your forearm or in a backpack.
- Use two hands where you used to use one, and slide heavy things across the counter where you'd once have lifted them.

- Hold things with a loose, open grip. Thick-handled pens, knives and tools make this easy.

PACE YOURSELF

- Break big jobs into pieces and rest briefly between them, before pain tells you to.
- Change position every 20 to 30 minutes. Joints dislike being held still.
- Spread demanding tasks across the week so no single day carries them all.

HELPFUL TOOLS ARE A SIGN OF WISDOM

- A jar opener, a kettle tipper and lever taps protect sore hands.
- Cushioned, supportive shoes ease knees and hips with every step.
- A walking stick, held in the hand opposite your sore leg, takes real load off a painful knee or hip. Guidelines strongly recommend one when it helps you move more.
- Thumb splints and knee braces are recommended for some people with osteoarthritis. A therapist can fit one properly.

MILESTONE 2

You know what soothes

Six chapters of relief are behind you. You don't need all of it. Choose what suits your life.

- [ ] I've chosen one food change that feels doable
- [ ] I've chosen one comfort for sore days (cream, warmth or cold)
- [ ] I've chosen one way to move that I don't dread
- [ ] I've chosen one change to make my nights or my days easier

COMING NEXT

You have the pieces. Now watch them come together into a single, simple day you can begin tomorrow morning.

PART THREE

Build

Knowledge becomes a way of living. In this part you'll shape a daily routine, a four-week plan and a kitchen that are entirely yours.

A safe daily routine

Here is a gentle day built from everything in this book that helps. Let it sit alongside whatever your doctor has prescribed, and make it your own.

MORNING

- [ ] Take prescribed medication as directed
- [ ] Warm stiff joints with a shower, heat pack or hot and cold water, then stretch gently for ten minutes
- [ ] A glass of water, no added salt

DURING THE DAY

- [ ] Thirty minutes of walking, swimming or cycling, split up if that is easier
- [ ] Vegetables or fruit with every meal; oily fish twice a week
- [ ] Turmeric and ginger in cooking
- [ ] Capsaicin cream on sore joints, three or four times
- [ ] Change position every half hour

EVENING

- [ ] Cold pack on any hot, swollen joint for 15 minutes
- [ ] A warm bath, a ginger poultice for up to an hour, or a castor oil compress overnight, if you find them soothing
- [ ] Two minutes of slow breathing, then a regular bedtime

TWICE A WEEK

- [ ] Strength exercises for the muscles around your sore joints

Give the routine six to eight weeks, and keep a simple pain score from 0 to 10 so you can see what changes.

Some days you'll tick every box and some days none. Both are fine. What changes things is coming back to it, not doing it perfectly.

COMING NEXT

A *whole routine at once can feel like a lot, so the next chapter hands it to you one small layer at a time.*

PART THREE · BUILD

Your first four weeks

You don't have to change everything at once. This plan adds one small layer each week, so that by the end of the month the routine feels like yours.

1 Begin gently

WHAT TO DO

Walk 10 minutes a day. Start capsaicin cream on your sorest joint. Write down your pain score each evening.

A KIND REMINDER

The cream may sting at first. That passes.

2 Feed your joints

WHAT TO DO

Add vegetables or fruit to every meal. Cook with turmeric and ginger. Swap one sugary drink a day for water.

A KIND REMINDER

One better meal a day is enough to begin.

3 Build strength

WHAT TO DO

Add the movement guide twice this week. Stretch your walk to 20 minutes. Use heat before and cold after if it helps.

A KIND REMINDER

A little soreness that fades in a day is normal.

4 Make it yours

WHAT TO DO

Reach 30 minutes of movement most days. Keep what helped, drop what didn't. Book a check-in with your doctor to share your notes.

A KIND REMINDER

Look back at week 1. Notice how far you've come.

If a week feels like too much, repeat the one before. There is no falling behind here.

CELEBRATE EACH WEEK

Finishing a week deserves marking. Pick a small reward in advance, something kind that has nothing to do with food rules or effort: a phone call with a friend, a new book, an hour in the garden, a long bath.

- [ ] Week 1 done
- [ ] Week 2 done
- [ ] Week 3 done
- [ ] Week 4 done

PICTURE THIS

It's four weeks from today. You've just finished your walk and you're writing down your pain score. What number would make you smile? And who is the first person you'll tell?

COMING NEXT

Week three asks you to build strength. The next chapter shows you exactly how, with ten movements you can do beside a kitchen chair.

PART THREE · BUILD

A gentle movement guide

These ten movements are kind to sore joints and need no equipment beyond a sturdy chair. Move slowly, breathe, and stop short of sharp pain. If you've had a joint replaced or a recent injury, ask your physiotherapist which ones suit you.

1. **Seated march.** Sit tall and lift one knee, then the other, for one minute. This warms the hips and knees.
2. **Sit to stand.** From a chair, stand up and sit back down slowly. Do 5 to 10. Use your hands at first if you need them.

3. **Heel raises.** Hold the chair back and rise onto your toes, then lower. Do 10. This steadies ankles and calves.
4. **Knee straightening.** Seated, straighten one leg, hold for five seconds, lower. Do 10 each side. Strong thighs protect knees.
5. **Side leg lift.** Hold the chair back and lift one leg out to the side, toes forward, then lower. Do 8 each side. Strong hips steady every step.
6. **Wall push-ups.** Hands on a wall, bend your elbows and press back. Do 8 to 10. Easier on wrists than the floor.
7. **Shoulder circles.** Roll both shoulders slowly backward 10 times, then forward 10 times.
8. **Hand opening.** Make a soft fist, then spread your fingers wide. Do 10. Lovely after warming your hands in water.
9. **Thumb touches.** Touch your thumb to each fingertip in turn, making a round "O" each time. Go through twice on each hand.
10. **Ankle circles.** Lift one foot and circle the ankle 10 times each way. Repeat on the other side.

Begin with one round. When that feels easy, do two. Twice a week is plenty to start, and every round is a gift to the joints that carry you.

COMING NEXT

Strong joints need good fuel. Next you'll get a shopping list and eight easy recipes, all chosen to be gentle on sore hands.

PART THREE · BUILD

Your joint-friendly kitchen

Good food won't cure arthritis, but it steadies your weight, lifts your energy and makes every other step easier. Here is a simple shopping list and eight recipes that ask very little of sore hands.

A SHOPPING LIST TO START WITH

- **Vegetables:** leafy greens, broccoli, carrots, tomatoes, peppers, onions
- **Fruit:** berries, cherries, oranges, apples

- **Protein:** salmon or sardines, lentils, chickpeas, eggs
- **Whole grains:** oats, brown rice, wholegrain bread
- **Good fats:** extra virgin olive oil, walnuts, almonds
- **Flavour:** turmeric, fresh ginger, garlic, black pepper, lemon

EIGHT EASY RECIPES

1. **Warm turmeric milk.** Heat a cup of milk or plant milk with half a teaspoon of turmeric, a pinch of black pepper and a little honey. A calming way to end the day.
2. **Fresh ginger tea.** Steep four or five slices of ginger in hot water for 10 minutes. Add lemon.
3. **Overnight oats.** Stir half a cup of oats into a cup of milk or yoghurt. Leave overnight. Top with berries and walnuts. No morning chopping needed.
4. **Cherry and berry smoothie.** Blend a cup of frozen cherries and berries with a banana and a cup of milk or yoghurt. Thirty seconds, no knife.

5. **Sardines on toast.** Mash tinned sardines with lemon and black pepper and pile onto wholegrain toast with sliced tomato. Omega-3s in five minutes.
6. **One-tray salmon.** Lay salmon and chopped vegetables on a tray, drizzle with olive oil and lemon, and bake at 200°C (400°F) for 15 to 20 minutes.
7. **Red lentil soup.** Simmer a cup of red lentils with a chopped onion, a carrot, a teaspoon of turmeric and four cups of stock for 25 minutes. It freezes well for hard days.
8. **Olive oil vegetable bowl.** Roast any vegetables you have, spoon over brown rice and chickpeas, and finish with olive oil and lemon.

KIND TO YOUR HANDS

Buy pre-chopped or frozen vegetables without guilt. Use a jar opener and a wide-handled knife. Cook double and freeze half, so a meal is waiting when your joints need a rest.

COMING NEXT

One last piece completes your plan: knowing exactly when to bring a doctor in, and which medical treatments work hand in hand with everything you've learned.

PART THREE · BUILD

When to see a doctor

Looking after yourself includes knowing when to bring someone in. If you don't have a diagnosis yet, start there, and please don't wait on any of the signs below.

SAME-DAY CARE

- One joint suddenly hot, red and very painful, especially with fever. This can be a joint infection.
- A joint that cannot bear weight after a fall or injury.

AN APPOINTMENT WITHIN WEEKS

- Swelling in several joints, or morning stiffness lasting more than an hour.

- Joint pain with rashes, fatigue, weight loss or eye problems.
- Pain that wakes you at night or keeps getting worse.

TREATMENTS THAT WORK ALONGSIDE NATURAL CARE

- **Osteoarthritis:** anti-inflammatory gels are strongly recommended for knees and are gentle on the rest of the body. Tablets, steroid injections and, when pain and function call for it, joint replacement are there if you need them.
- **Rheumatoid arthritis:** disease-modifying drugs such as methotrexate. Starting early is what prevents lasting joint damage.
- **Gout:** urate-lowering medication such as allopurinol if flares recur, usually aiming for a blood uric acid level below 6 mg/dL.

Tell your doctor and pharmacist about every herb and supplement you use.

Asking for medical help is not giving up on natural care. It's what gives everything else in this book the chance to work.

MILESTONE 3

You have a plan

A routine, a month mapped out, movements you can do beside a chair and meals that go easy on your hands. This is the part most people never get to.

- [ ] I've set a start date for week 1
- [ ] I've told one person what I'm doing, so someone is cheering for me

COMING NEXT

A plan is only as good as its worst day. In the final part, you'll make sure yours holds on the days that test you.

PART FOUR

Keep going

This is the part that makes the change last. A plan for hard days, the right questions to ask, and answers for the moments you doubt yourself.

Your flare-day plan

Hard days will come, and they don't mean you've done anything wrong. Having a plan ready means you can be gentle with yourself instead of frightened.

1. **Rest the joint, not your whole body.** Ease off the sore joint for a day or two, but keep the rest of you moving a little.
2. **Cool what is hot, warm what is stiff.** A wrapped cold pack for 15 minutes on a swollen joint; warmth on a stiff one.
3. **Take your relief as directed.** Use the pain relief your doctor or pharmacist has recommended. Needing it is not a failure.
4. **Keep it simple in the kitchen.** This is what the frozen soup is for.
5. **Do the smallest version.** Ankle circles and hand opening still count on a flare day.
6. **Breathe out slowly.** Ten slow breaths settle a frightened nervous system and soften guarded muscles.

7. **Note what came before.** A long day on your feet, poor sleep, a missed dose? Patterns help you and your doctor.
8. **Know when to call.** A flare lasting more than a few days, or a single joint that is hot, red and very painful, deserves a call to your doctor.

Flares pass. You've come through every one so far.

COMING NEXT

You'll get far more from every appointment with the right questions in your pocket. They're on the next page.

PART FOUR · KEEP GOING

Questions to bring to your doctor

You are allowed to ask questions, and good doctors welcome them. Bring this page with you and tick them off as you go.

- [ ] Which type of arthritis do I have, and how sure are we?
- [ ] What is the goal of my treatment: less pain, protecting my joints, or both?
- [ ] Which exercises are safest for my joints, and can I be referred to a physiotherapist?
- [ ] I'd like to use capsaicin cream, turmeric or ginger. Is that safe with my medication?
- [ ] Would losing weight help in my case, and what support is available?
- [ ] Would a splint, brace or walking stick help me?
- [ ] What should I do during a flare, and when should I call you?
- [ ] How often should we review how things are going?

Bring your tracker too. A few weeks of notes tells your doctor more than memory can.

PART FOUR · KEEP GOING

Your weekly tracker

Two minutes each evening is all it takes, and over a few weeks it will show you what truly helps your body. Copy these six lines into a notebook, or the notes on your phone, and fill them in each night.

- **Pain today**, from 0 to 10
- **Morning stiffness**, in minutes
- **Movement I did**
- **How I slept**
- **Something that helped**
- **One thing I'm proud of**

BE YOUR OWN DETECTIVE

This is the best habit in her whole talk. Look at your history, notice your symptoms, change one thing, and watch how your body responds. Your tracker turns that into evidence you can show your doctor.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

After two weeks, read back through your notes. Which days were your best, and what did they have in common? That pattern is your personal remedy, and no book could have told it to you.

Small wins are how this works. Write them down so you can see them.

PART FOUR · KEEP GOING

Questions people often ask

How soon will I feel a difference?

Capsaicin cream usually needs two to four weeks. Exercise often eases stiffness within a few weeks, with more benefit over two to three months. Be patient with yourself.

Can I do this instead of my medication?

Only after speaking with your doctor. Everything here is meant to work with your treatment. If you'd like to take less medication, your doctor can lower it safely as you improve, and a good tracker makes it easier.

Exercise hurts. Should I stop?

Gentle discomfort that settles within a day is safe and expected. Sharp pain, or pain that lingers, means do less next time, not nothing.

Will exercise wear out my joints?

No. Sensible movement feeds cartilage and strengthens the muscles that protect it. Stillness is what joints fear.

Is cracking or creaking a bad sign?

Usually not. Joints that click without pain or swelling are simply noisy.

Does the weather really affect arthritis?

Many people feel worse in cold, damp weather, and you're not imagining it. Keep warm, keep moving, and know that it passes when the weather does.

Are the remedies safe with other health conditions?

Mostly, but check turmeric and ginger supplements with a pharmacist if you take blood thinners or diabetes medication, and avoid capsaicin on broken skin.

Her talk says people heal completely. Can I?

Symptoms can ease a great deal, and rheumatoid arthritis and gout can go quiet for years with the right treatment. The joint changes of osteoarthritis don't reverse, but pain and stiffness often improve so much that life opens up again. Aim for that, and let anything more be a bonus.

Am I too old to start?

You are not. People in their seventies, eighties and nineties gain strength and ease from gentle exercise. The best day to begin is the one you're in.

I've tried everything and I'm tired. Is it worth it?

Your tiredness makes sense. You don't need to try everything again. Pick the single smallest step in week 1 and begin there. That is enough for today.

PART FOUR · KEEP GOING

You made it

You reached the last chapter, and that alone says something about you. Reading a whole book about your own pain takes patience and courage.

Before you close it, look back for a moment. When you opened this book you may have felt confused, tired of conflicting advice and unsure where to begin. Now you know which remedies deserve your trust. You have a routine, a plan for hard days and questions ready for your doctor. That is real progress, and it's yours.

MILESTONE 4

You're ready to keep going

- [ ] I finished the book
- [ ] I've started my tracker
- [ ] I know what I'll do on my next flare day

A PROMISE TO MYSELF

Say these aloud, or write them where you'll see them.

- The one small thing I'll do every day
- The reason I'm doing this
- The person I'll call when it gets hard
- What I'll be doing again in three months

WHERE TO GO FROM HERE

Start week 1 tomorrow. Come back to the flare-day plan when you need it. Reread "Before you begin" in a month and notice what has changed.

Be gentle with yourself. You're doing better than you think.

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- Comfrey root ointment in knee osteoarthritis: a three-week trial in 220 people.
- Tomato consumption and serum urate: tomatoes as a reported gout trigger.
- Arthritis: Should You Avoid Nightshade Vegetables?, Cleveland Clinic: the two-week elimination test.

Statements on castor oil, juices, lemon water, salt, Epsom salts, cherries, tea and coffee, wheat, dairy, cooked greens, comfrey safety, meal timing, smoking,

turmeric doses, nose breathing, sleep, joint protection and pain science reflect general medical knowledge and were not checked against a specific page for this edition.

This book is for general information. It is not medical advice and does not replace the care of your own doctor.